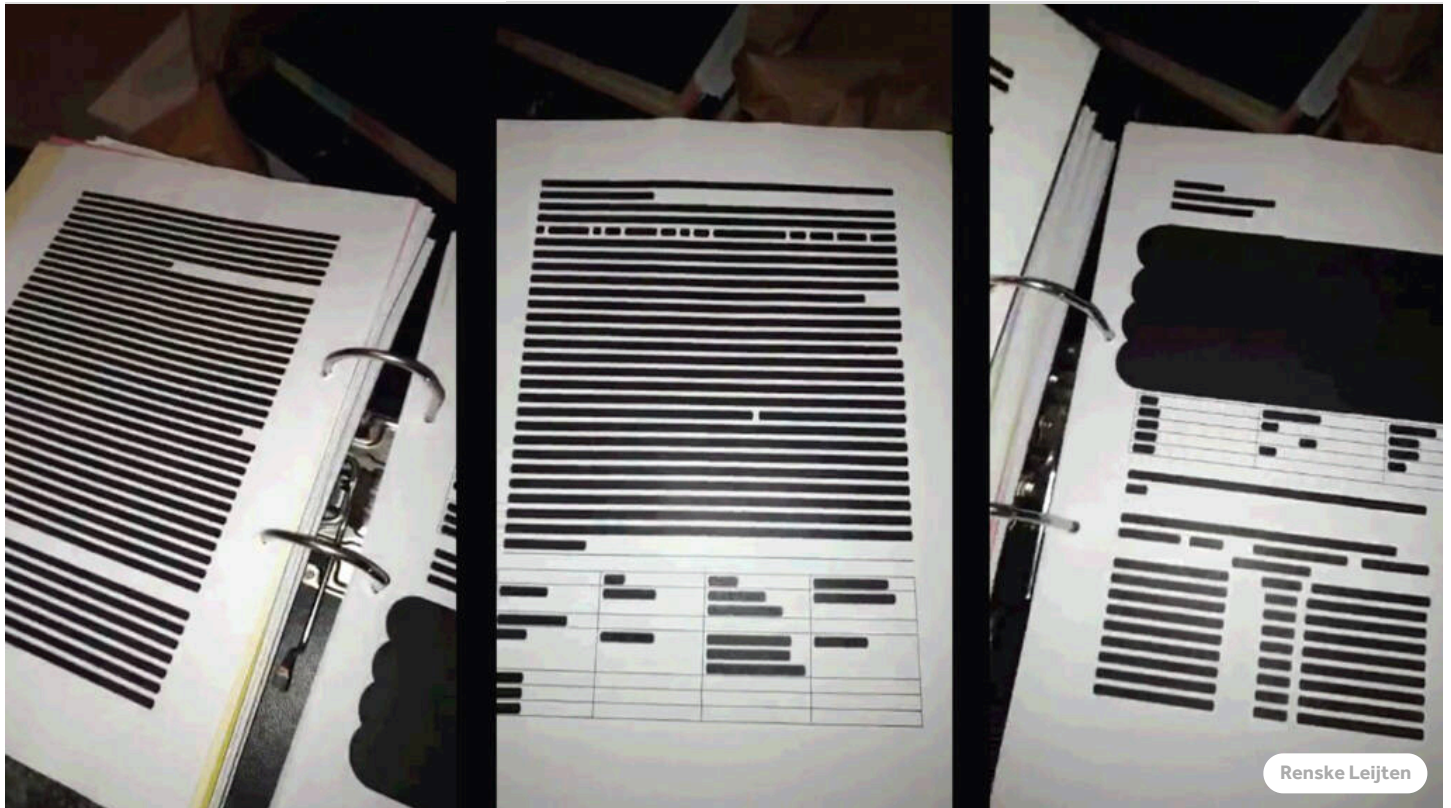




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Parents of blacked-out files: 'I still don't know what I did wrong'

Parents affected by the childcare allowance scandal thought that, after countless letters, phone calls, and a debate in the House of Representatives, they were finally being heard by the Tax and Customs Administration. They had been promised access to their files, but upon receipt, it turns out that much of the information they are looking for has been redacted.

"Everything has been scratched out for me," says Nazmiyue Karaduman. "I still don't know what I did wrong according to the Tax Authorities."

Karaduman leafed through the files with us to show what is (not) in them:

2:48

Official notes, newspaper articles, and much redacted in files

Karaduman, like hundreds of other childcare allowance recipients, was wrongly labeled a fraudster. Many people fell into financial difficulties, sometimes with major consequences. Some lost their homes or jobs, or their partners, due to the persistent stress and uncertainty. They often still have no idea why they were accused.

Last month, following [a demonstration](#), the Tax and Customs Administration promised that everyone who came forward would receive access to their file. Yesterday, the first parents were sent that information, or at least: part of it.

Surely this can't be right?

Data can indeed be found in the three binders Karaduman received yesterday, but by her own account, that is of no use to her. A large part concerns the 't Voortvarend Scheepje childcare center in Rotterdam, where she took her children when she went to work. She already knew everything in the file that concerns her, because it comes from her own correspondence with the Tax Authorities.

"I don't know what to do with this," she says. "It's all so vague. A lot is blacked out, and in other places I see names that I really shouldn't be reading. I see another woman's parental contribution listed, and her name is just there. Surely that can't be right?"

According to André Karels, the spokesperson for State Secretary for Finance Menno Snel, all data redacted in the files belongs to others. "For example, information from

the childcare organization and names, social security numbers, and addresses of other parents have been redacted. "tweeted" he this morning.

I think my DigiD was misused by the childcare center, but I still don't know for sure.

— Dulce Goncalves Tavares

"He might say that, but my social security number has been redacted too," says Dulce Goncalves Tavares. Just like Karaduman, she received three folders in the mail last night. In the first two, virtually everything was redacted; the third folder contained a little information about her situation.

"I thought I would see certain things reflected. That I could correct the mistake made by the Tax Authorities, by me, or by the after-school care. But I couldn't find anything."

In total, according to the tax authorities, she allegedly defrauded the tax authorities of 125,000 euros. "But I wouldn't know how. The money went directly to the childcare. I think my DigiD was misused by the childcare, but I still don't know for sure."

Snel 'understands the commotion'

The "page-long redacted sections give a distorted picture," State Secretary Snel writes today in a letter to the House of Representatives. Snel now says that it concerns a report on a tax audit at a childcare institution, containing, among other things, information on turnover and wage data "in which only one line relates to the citizen in question".

Goncalves Tavares spent three years in debt restructuring. This month, she can access her own wages again for the first time. "I want to move on. It has caused stress for years. I have a good job and want to give my three children what they earn, but I was never able to."

Neither woman knows how to proceed now. "I am going to do what Renske says now," says Karaduman, referring to SP MP Renske Leijten. Together with Pieter Omtzigt of the CDA, she has championed the affected group of parents for years.

Leijten is requesting a debate on the matter in the House today. "If she says: 'hire a lawyer,' then I will do that. But for now, I will just wait and see what happens next."